Databricks Data Engineer Associate

REVISED 18-Day Study Plan • Exam: July 11, 2026 at 7:00 AM

Exam 01 Score	Improvement	Target Score
33 / 45	**+5 pts**	**37+ / 45**
73.33% — PASSING ✓	+11.33% from baseline	Safe buffer — ~82%

You're already passing (33/45 = 73.33%). The passing threshold is 32/45. This plan targets 37+ by laser-focusing on your 12 remaining wrong answers. Fix Priority 1 (SQL DDL + Architecture) alone = +4–6 points.

Your Performance Snapshot

✓ What's Solid — Light review only

– DLT & Workflows — zero misses this round

– Governance — GRANT syntax locked in (Q44, Q45)

– Jobs — retry policy, task deps solid (Q37–39)

– Streaming fundamentals — Auto Loader basics ok

■■ Needs Laser Focus — 12 questions

– SQL DDL Syntax — Q9, Q16, Q17 (3 misses, highest ROI)

– Databricks Architecture — Q2, Q5, Q8 (foundational)

– Table Operations — Q15 (caching/conversion)

– Syntax & Transformations — Q21, Q24, Q28, Q31, Q40

The 12 Wrong Answers — Priority Action Plan

Q	Topic	Yours	Answer	Gap	Pri
Q2	Control Plane vs Data Plane	B	A	Where driver/worker nodes live	P1
Q5	Data Explorer for Table Permissions	B	C	Permissions UI location	P1
Q8	Delta Lake Definition	A	B	Delta Lake = format, not engine	P1
Q9	CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE Syntax	C	B	Confused CTAS vs inline DDL	P1
Q15	External Parquet Caching Fix	D	A	Convert to Delta to fix stale	P1

Q 16	CTAS Schema Inference	B	A	Schema auto-inferred from query	P1
Q 17	Table Overwrite vs Delete/Recreate	D	B	OVERWRITE keeps old version	P1
Q 21	Nested Struct Field Access	D	B	Use dot notation payload.date	P2
Q 24	Python F-String Formatting	B	D	No + operators in f-strings	P2
Q 31	Bronze→Silver Transformation	D	C	Enrich/clean = Silver hop	P2
Q 28	Auto Loader Implementation	A	C	cloudFiles format = Auto Loader	P3
Q 40	SQL Endpoint Optimization	E	C	Sequential → cluster size	P3

● P1 = Priority 1 — Highest ROI (7 questions) ● P2 = Priority 2 — Medium impact (3 questions) ● P3 = Polish (2 questions)

The 12-Question Nightly Drill — Jun 23–29

> Answer 1 question per night from memory — no notes. Cover the answer first.

```
Q2: Where do driver/worker nodes live? (Control plane or data plane?)
Q5: Where do you manage table permissions in the Databricks UI?
Q8: What is Delta Lake? (A format? A service? An engine?)
Q9: Difference between CREATE TABLE, CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE, and CTAS?
Q15: External Parquet files + stale cache → what do you do?
Q16: CREATE TABLE AS SELECT — does it infer schema? What if table exists?
Q17: OVERWRITE TABLE vs DROP + CREATE — key behavioral difference?
Q21: Access nested field — payload.date or payload['date']?
Q24: Write f-string with 3 variables — exact syntax?
Q28: What does format('cloudFiles') enable?
Q31: Bronze→Silver transformation — what operations happen?
Q40: Slow sequential queries at SQL endpoint — cluster size or scaling range?
```

WEEK 1 — Jun 23–29 • Fix Priority 1 Topics

Tue
Jun 23
1.5 hrs

Architecture Deep Dive

Architecture

– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 1:19:32 — Cluster Types (control plane vs data plane)
– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 1:51:53 — Databricks Web Application
– Write out: Control Plane vs Data Plane definitions 10 times
– Read Module 1 PDF — Lakehouse benefits section
– Do 5 ExamTopics questions on ‘control plane’, ‘data plane’, ‘ACID’
– Key: driver/worker nodes live in the DATA PLANE (your VPC). Web UI = control plane.

```
CONTROL PLANE (Databricks VPC): Web UI, REST API, cluster scheduler
DATA PLANE (Your VPC): Driver node, worker nodes, storage
DELTA LAKE: Open-source format (Parquet + txn log)
ACID guarantees + time travel
```

✓ *Exit Criteria: Can explain where the driver node lives without hesitation.*

■ freeCodeCamp full course (YouTube)
■ Module 1 PDF (Databricks Workspace)
■ ExamTopics — Architecture questions

Wed
Jun 24
2 hrs

SQL DDL Behavior

SQL DDL

– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 3:03:32 — Delta Lake (CTAS + OVERWRITE sections only)
– Read Module 3 PDF — CREATE TABLE AS SELECT and OVERWRITE pages
– Write by hand: all 3 CREATE/OVERWRITE patterns (see below)
– Practice: Re-answer Q9, Q15, Q16, Q17 — explain each answer out loud

```
CREATE TABLE x (id STRING, val INT) → Empty table, explicit schema
CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE x (id STRING, ...) → Drops old, creates new (empty
CREATE TABLE x AS SELECT ... → Infers schema from SELECT, fails if exists
CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE x AS SELECT ... → Infers schema, replaces existing
INSERT OVERWRITE x SELECT ... → Replaces data, keeps schema + history
External Parquet + stale cache → Convert to Delta format
```

✓ *Exit Criteria: Can explain all 3 CREATE patterns and the caching fix without notes.*

■ freeCodeCamp full course (YouTube)
■ Module 3 PDF (Delta Lake)

Thu
Jun 25
1 hr

DLT Review — Light Touch

DLT

– You had ZERO DLT misses this round — skim only, no deep dive
– Skim DLT Full Course highlights (first 30 min) — confirm CREATE LIVE TABLE syntax
– Quick read Module 4 PDF — EXPECT constraint behavior only
– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:44:42 — Auto Loader (Q28 fix)
– Key: format('cloudFiles') IS Auto Loader — no separate .autoLoader line needed

```
cloudFiles Auto Loader: .format('cloudFiles') ← THIS enables it. Nothing e
needed.
EXPECT constraint: Records added to table AND flagged in event log (not dro
DROP ON VIOLATION: Records dropped | FAIL ON VIOLATION: Job fails
```

■ Delta Live Tables Full Course (YouTube)
■ Module 4 PDF (Delta Live Tables)

Fri
Jun 26
1.5 hrs

Struct Access, F-Strings & Streaming

Spark SQL

– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:04:23 — Spark DataFrame API
– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:39:38 — Structured Streaming / medallion
– Write: 10 struct field access examples using dot notation
– Write: 5 f-string examples with 2–3 variables each
– Practice: Q21, Q24, Q31 + 5 ExamTopics syntax questions

```
Struct access: payload.date ← CORRECT (dot notation)
payload['date'] ← WRONG (bracket notation)
F-string: f"{region}{store}_sales_{year}" ← no + operators
Bronze→Silver: .withColumn() / filter / enrich + outputMode('append')
Silver→Gold: .groupBy().agg() + outputMode('complete')
```

✓ *Exit Criteria: Zero syntax mistakes on Q21 and Q24 style questions. Can explain medallion hop*

■ freeCodeCamp full course (YouTube)
■ Module 2 PDF (Transform Data with Spark)

Sat
Jun 27
1 hr

Jobs, SQL Endpoints & Auto Loader Polish

Jobs & SQL

– Watch freeCodeCamp @ 6:49:58 — Jobs, Monitoring, Visualization
– Read Module 5 PDF — cluster sizing and job config sections
– Key: slow sequential queries → increase CLUSTER SIZE (workers), not scaling range
– Scaling range = helps concurrent users; cluster size = helps one user’s query speed
– Review Q40 + 3 ExamTopics SQL endpoint questions

■ freeCodeCamp full course (YouTube)
■ Module 5 PDF (Databricks Workflows)

Sun
Jun 28
2 hrs

Mock Exam + Review

Practice

– Take DatabricksCertifiedAssociateDataEngineerExam.pdf — all 45 questions, timed 90 min
– Do NOT look up answers while taking it
– Score yourself; note every wrong answer by topic area
– Target: 36+ /45. If below, flag remaining topics for Week 2 extra time

■ Mock Exam PDF (Amrit-Hub GitHub)

Mon
Jun 29
1.5 hrs

Review Mock Exam Misses

Practice

– Go through every wrong answer from Sunday — read full explanation for each
– Use ExamTopics discussions to understand WHY the correct answer is right
– Re-read only the Module PDFs for topics missed 2+ times
– Do a focused 15-question ExamTopics session on those specific topics

■ ExamTopics — free practice questions

WEEK 2 — Jun 30 – Jul 6 • Reinforce & Fill Remaining Gaps

Day	Focus	Key Actions	Duration
Tue Jun 30	Auto Loader deep dive	Watch @ 5:44:42; 3 ExamTopics Auto Loader questions; confirm cloudFiles format	1h
Wed Jul 1	DLT revision + DBSQL	Re-watch DLT section; review query scheduling Q41–Q43; key: schedule from query page not Jobs UI	1h
Thu Jul 2	Governance & Unity Catalog	Watch @ 6:55:54 (Unity Catalog); confirm GRANT SELECT vs ALL PRIVILEGES; practice Q44, Q45	1h
Fri Jul 3	ExamTopics deep practice	25 questions focused on DDL, Architecture, Table Ops; read community discussion for every miss	2h
Sat Jul 4	SECOND FULL EXAM (Timed)	Retake official Databricks practice exam PDF; strictly 90 min, no notes; target 38+/45	2h
Sun Jul 5	Weak topic blitz	Review every wrong answer from Sat; 20-question ExamTopics session on remaining gaps only	1.5h
Mon Jul 6	ExamTopics broad practice	30 mixed questions across all topic areas; target 90%+ correct; note any new patterns	1.5h

■ Resources for Week 2: ExamTopics — examtopics.com/exams/databricks/certified-data-engineer-associate/view/ | ITExams — itexams.com/info/Certified-Data-Engineer-Associate | Official Exam PDF — github.com/Amrit-Hub (PracticeExam-DataEngineerAssociate.pdf)

WEEK 3 — Jul 7–11 • Final Polish & Exam Day

Tue
Jul 7
1 hr

Rapid-Fire Key Facts Review

Practice

– Write out the 20 most important facts from your study (no peeking at notes)
– Focus: SQL DDL patterns, data plane location, medallion hops, EXPECT behavior
– Do 20 ExamTopics questions — aim for 90%+ correct
– Read Amrit-Hub README topic list — answer each bullet from memory

■ Amrit-Hub topic list
■ ExamTopics practice

Wed
Jul 8
2 hrs

Final Full Mock — Simulate Exam Conditions

Practice

– Use ITExams or ExamTopics for a fresh 45-question set — strictly 90 min, no help
– Target: 40+ correct
– After scoring: spend max 1 hour on any remaining weak spots
– After that, stop studying new material completely

■ ITExams — free practice questions
■ ExamTopics practice

Thu
Jul 9
0.5 hr

Light Review Only — No New Material

Rest

– Skim your personal key facts list once — 30 minutes maximum
– Confirm exam login credentials, time zone (7 AM), and room setup
– Make sure valid ID is ready for proctoring
– Sleep well — this matters more than any extra study hour

Fri
Jul 10

Rest Day — Brain Consolidation

Rest

– No studying — seriously. Your brain consolidates knowledge during rest.
– Light walk, good meal, early bedtime
– Glance at key facts list once if it helps — then put it away
– Set alarm for 6:00 AM for the 7:00 AM exam

Sat
Jul 11

EXAM DAY — Databricks Certified Data Engineer Associate

Exam 7AM

– Wake 6:00 AM — light breakfast, coffee, no last-minute cramming
– Log in 15 minutes early for proctoring setup and ID check
– Read every question fully before answering — eliminate wrong answers first
– Flag uncertain questions and revisit — 2 minutes per question average
– You need 32. You're already at 33. With this prep you'll be at 37+. You've got this.

Study Time Summary

Topic	Priority	Est. Time	Expected Gain
SQL DDL (CTAS, OVERWRITE, caching)	1	3 hrs	+2–3 pts
Databricks Architecture (planes, Delta)	1	2.5 hrs	+2–3 pts
Struct / F-String syntax	2	1.5 hrs	+1–2 pts
Medallion Architecture (Bronze→Gold)	2	1 hr	+1 pt
Auto Loader / SQL Endpoints	3	1.5 hrs	+0–1 pt
Practice exams + review	—	5 hrs	+consolidation
TOTAL	—	~14.5 hrs	Baseline 33 → 37+

Path to success: Baseline 33/45 (73.33%) + 6 pts from Priority 1 fixes = **39/45 (86.67%) ✓** — well above the 32/45 passing threshold

Exam Day Checklist

- ■ Valid ID ready (driver's license or passport)
- ■ Proctoring software downloaded and tested before exam day
- ■ Exam time zone confirmed — 7:00 AM your local time
- ■ Quiet, distraction-free room booked
- ■ Phone off or silenced
- ■ Log in 15–20 minutes early for setup
- ■ Light breakfast and coffee — no heavy meal
- ■ Key facts list reviewed once only (Thursday morning) — then put away
- ■ Alarm set for 6:00 AM on July 11

You're Already Passing. Now Execute.

You've made an 11% improvement already. Fix the 12 weak questions and you'll hit 37+.

18 days. 12 questions. Let's go. ■■